

Economic Shocks and Consumption Smoothing Using Online Crowdfunding*

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Abstract

Federal and State aid through welfare programs, like unemployment insurance, act as a consumption smoothing mechanism during unemployment spells and economic downturns. Individuals have recently begun to crowdfund to pay for regular expenses that traditionally savings or unemployment insurance would cover. No work has explored how peer-to-peer online crowdfunding is utilized to smooth consumption, and how economic conditions affect that. Using data from GoFundMe, an online crowdfunding site, I estimate the effects that changes in labor market conditions and federal changes to unemployment benefits have on the utilization of crowdfunding. I present difference-in-difference and event study estimates that show a statistically significant increase in campaigns published in states with worse economic conditions and a decrease for states with earlier access to federal UI. I find that campaigns are less successful, on average, with a dedicated fundraising category that is sensitive to different demographics and campaign factors.

Keywords: crowdfunding, donations, unemployment insurance, benefits, unemployment

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1 Introduction

Large labor market fluctuations and persistent health concerns from the COVID-19 pandemic created widespread economic uncertainty in early 2020. Despite declining economic conditions, online crowdfunding on GoFundMe grew in both the number of campaigns published and the number of donations made. As of 2025, GoFundMe is the largest online crowdfunding platform in the world where people can seamlessly donate online to a variety of charities and personal campaigns. Part of this growth has been driven by the economic-induced hardships millions of Americans faced over the past few years. Tim Cadogan, the CEO of GoFundMe, acknowledged this in a 2021 article stating, "In October (2020), after seeing a steady rise in fundraising from people struggling to pay bills like rent and utilities, we created a new category for those on our site. In just a few months, it has grown into one of the largest categories on the platform, accounting for 13% of fundraisers".¹ Despite the growing cases of emergency crowdfunding for financial reasons, little to no work has examined the causes of these campaigns, the use of crowdfunding as a consumption smoothing mechanism, and the economic cyclicalities of non-tax-deductible charitable giving.

I use a rich online data set from a popular crowdfunding site, GoFundMe, to examine the effects economic conditions have on online campaigning and donating; highlighting how these differ for financial emergency campaigns and how much the quality of the campaign affects its success (meeting the stated goal amount), the amount raised, and the size and number of donations received.

The first contribution of the paper is to examine how access to UI benefit extensions, both at the intensive and extensive margin, affects overall crowdfunding at the state level. Given the large spike in unemployment during the COVID-19 pandemic and changes to federal UI policy, state UI programs were unable to uniformly disperse federal benefit payments due to the inherent limitations of their program infrastructures. This creates variation in the timeliness in which states could disburse benefits. My identification strategy relies on

¹GoFundMe CEO: Hello Congress, Americans need help and we can't do your job for you

this staggered timing of benefit payments from federal UI programs under the CARES act, that conditional on state and time-fixed effects, is unrelated to unobserved determinants of charitable campaigning. I perform other robustness checks to show the effect is concentrated for campaigns correlated with routine expenses like rent and other monthly bills.

The second contribution explores a broader phenomenon of using personal crowdfunding as a consumption smoothing mechanism. Traditional resources such as unemployment insurance, and other means-tested programs, have been reduced in recent years and seen declining uptake (Forsythe and Yang, 2021). The adoption of this new GoFundMe (GFM) category, for financial emergencies, and its growing use suggest that online crowdfunding is a potential substitute to public insurance goods and smaller formal risk sharing networks like private cash transfers from family members (Panjwani and Xiong, 2023) (Anne, 2020). I also test this sentiment across different demographics and observable fund characteristics to test the degree to which fund success may vary. Imputed measures for race and gender indirectly prescribe discriminatory effects where non-white campaigners are less likely to reach their goal amount, on average.

The main findings align with previous literature showing that access to federal public insurance lead to a decrease in the number of GoFundMe campaigns published in certain categories. Specifically, when states were dispersing benefits, there was a statistically significant decrease of approximately 15.6% in financial emergency campaigns. Business-category campaigns showed a directionally similar but statistically insignificant decline of 5.9%. Overall, these results suggest to some extent that increases to UI benefits, along the external margin, mitigate financial and economic pressures and supplement consumption. Extensive work has looked at the effects of extended (or increased) UI benefits on consumption

2 Literature Review

2.1 Charitable Giving Literature

Crowdfunding is a growing area of economic research as platforms continue to develop for different causes. Many platforms started as for-profit business ventures to generate new products. These crowdfunding ventures can provide more efficient outcomes than traditional capital raising ventures through better market signaling, coordination, and reduced transaction costs (Agrawal et al.). Crowdfunding often suffers from problems of moral hazard and asymmetric information in which campaign quality (descriptive campaign factors) can affect the likelihood of success (Andreoni and Payne, 2013; Chang, 2020).

Much of the literature has focused on the price of giving (from a tax or efficiency perspective) where results have ranged significantly. (Panjwani and Xiong, 2023) find that a removal of the 5% donation fee on GoFundMe in November 2017 led to an increase in donation amounts of up to 17%, which aligns with previous findings on the elasticity of charitable giving (Peloza and Steel, 2005). This work circumvents confounding price effects given no overhead costs to campaigners and a small, uniform fee for donors from the platform. (Meer, 2014) finds strong negative price elasticity and competition effects for online crowdfunding campaigns focused on school supplies for teachers.

Some work has explored the effect of distance on charitable giving and social connectedness. (Meer and Rigbi, 2013) find that distance, measured by language of origin of donation, has little effect on the success or funding decisions for campaigns on Kiva (a micro loan platform). (Deryugina and Marx, 2021) find a statistically significant increase in the number of donations, using IRS tax data, in areas 20 miles outside of the paths of deadly tornadoes, suggesting that overall supply of donations increases in response to a sudden shock and does not reallocate donations from other causes. Familiarity and interpersonal ties lead to larger donations when solicited (Meer, 2011). (Chetty, 2008) shows that much of the social disconnection between low-socioeconomic status individuals and high-socioeconomic status

individuals is a result of lack of exposure between the two in groups like school and religious organizations. This could suggest that lower-income individuals have a disadvantage at crowdfunding due to smaller and lower socioeconomic networks.

2.2 Consumption Smoothing Literature

Previous research has traditionally looked at the effects of public insurance or savings levels on consumption behavior when faced with income shocks. Seminal work by (Gruber, 1997) found that UI acts as a consumption stabilizer where the level of UI benefits received positively correlates with consumption. (East and Kuka, 2015) shows that UI acts as the largest cushion against income loss but this effect is a function of income, with low earners having less of their overall earnings replaced compared to middle and high earners. Much work has also examined the effect of federally extended benefits on consumption and job finding behavior. Household income changes can affect monthly consumption with black and Hispanic households being more sensitive to transitory income shocks (Ganong et al., 2020). Individuals also experience a large drop in consumption once they exhaust unemployment benefits and the largest gains in consumption come from extending benefits rather than increasing the level of benefits (Ganong and Noel, 2019). (Anne, 2020) shows that conditional on unemployment, workers are more likely to receive private cash transfers from family members suggesting there's a positive correlation between unemployment and private cash transfers. My work contributes to the literature by examining the effect that unemployment benefits have on the level of crowdfunding and subsequent success, which has not been researched prior.

3 Background

3.1 GoFundMe

Online crowdfunding is a relatively recent phenomenon and has gained traction due to the ease and effectiveness of creating fundraising campaigns. GoFundMe, a popular crowdfunding site, has raised more than \$15 Billion dollars since its inception in 2010 and is the largest online platform to date.² Figure 1 shows an example of a typical GoFundMe page. The premise is simple: people create campaigns for a cause they would like to raise money for which anyone can donate to until the goal is met or the person closes the campaign. While it's primarily known as a way to raise money for health issues or reasons, individuals can campaign for a variety of motivations including helping pay for education, community expenses, business or product startups, and more. The main data of interest, include the total amount raised, the goal amount, and donors and their respective donations.

GoFundMe is unique in that it minimizes transaction costs associated with crowdfunding. There are no overhead or variable costs to campaigners while there's a fixed rate fee to donors per donation. Organizers receive all funds donated to their campaign. This type of funding, considered a flexible funding format, is generally more successful on average compared to fixed funding formats, where the campaigner does not receive any funding if the funding threshold (goal) is not met. Chang (2020).

3.2 COVID-19, the CARES ACT, and other Federal Programs

In March 2020, congress proposed the Coronavirus Aid, Relief, and Economic Security (CARES) Act which significantly increased UI benefits in the U.S. Among these programs created included the Federal Pandemic Unemployment Compensation (FPUC) plan, the Pandemic Emergency Unemployment Compensation (PEUC), and the Pandemic Unemployment Assistance (PUA) program. These programs extended and increased regular unemployment

²<https://www.gofundme.com/c/gofundme-giving-report-2021>

benefit payments by \$600 for all unemployed workers, extended the duration of regular benefits by 13 weeks, and increased the set of workers covered to include contractors, gig workers, and the self-employed, respectively. The challenge involving these federal programs was determining the rise in unemployment due to the pandemic compared to cyclical unemployment which posed to be difficult for states in the U.S. Given inherent differences in states' UI program infrastructure, the timing after federal policy implementation (3/27/2020) to states accepting claims and disbursing UI benefits, varied widely between states. For example, applicants in some states automatically received federal benefits through their traditional UI claims, compared to other states where applicants had to apply and be approved for these federal benefits separately. I use the latter variation, in the timing of payment disbursement, to identify the impact of increases in UI generosity on crowdfunding campaigns published in states.

In Figure 2, we see the varied timing of initial payments from programs under the CARES act and subsequent federal policies. I focus on the start of the FPUC program as it was the first federal program to be dispersed and had the largest impact (by magnitude and volume). The FPUC program initially ended at the end of July 2020 where several weeks passed until funding from the Lost Wages Assistance (LWA) program was made available. Funding from the LWA came from appropriated Federal Emergency Management Association (FEMA) funds which led to a different set of requirements for approval and overall differing disbursement dates.

The LWA was the only federal UI top-up until the CARES Act programs were reinstated in January 2021 through the Continued Assistance Act, which provided benefits until March 2021. Along with this were funds provided by the Mixed Earners Unemployment Compensation (MEUC) program which provided an additional \$100 payment to individuals who had both W2 earnings as well as self-employment earnings.

CARES act programs were extended in March 2021 through September 4th, 2021 by the American Rescue Plan, however, at a lower level of \$300 per week. As the economy

continued to recover, this raised questions of whether the federal benefits created labor supply disincentives. Citing these issues, approximately 26 states ended all these federal benefits early (primarily in June and July of 2021) which led to substantial increases in employment levels for states terminating these programs early (Holzer et al., 2021).

It's important to note that prior to the pandemic, the insured unemployment rate had been falling in the U.S. for the past decade (Forsythe and Yang, 2021). The expansion of federal regulations increased the number of insured workers (both due to COVID-19 and job type) but also sharply increased the replacement rates for workers, to upwards of 100% Ganong et al. (2020). Thus, the CARES act generated arguably the most generous period of UI benefits in the history of the U.S. which led to significant effects on workers.

4 Data

4.1 GoFundMe

My data set was collected by web scraping the site www.GoFundMe.org in February 2024. The data acquired includes a sample of campaigns that have been posted on the site since 2010. Some campaigns become inactive and/or are removed from the site, in which case I do not capture these campaigns if this occurred prior to the scraping date. Ultimately, this skews the data toward more recent campaigns since older campaigns are more likely to become inactive. These data include many campaign details but factors of interest include amount raised, goal amount, number of donations, number of donors, description, donation size, date created, and location.

In Table 13, I list summary statistics for all campaigns over the sample period. We see that on average, campaigns are not very successful. The mean goal amount for campaigns is approximately \$13,580 but the mean amount raised is approximately \$6,469. Despite these numbers, the average rate of meeting the goal amount is only 23% over this time period. Other noticeable measures include the number of shares on social media and total

donations. Despite campaigns averaging over 300 shares between 2020 and 2021, campaigns only brought in approximately 71 donations on average.

In Figure 3, I plot the number of monthly campaigns over time by major GoFundMe categories. There’s a steady increase in the number of campaigns published after the pandemic officially started in early 2020. We see the largest increases in the memorial, emergency, medical and community categories which would align with the pandemic risks during the time. Other major categories also see a slight uptick around the start of the pandemic but seem to settle back to their pre-pandemic level over time. (Noticeably the adoption of a new category, "financial emergency," experiences a large increase in late 2020 after it is officially announced suggesting that the platform had been supplementing financial emergencies through other categories prior to the new category.)

4.2 American Community Survey Data

The American Community Survey is a U.S. Census Bureau administered survey that collects economic and demographic information on households. Using the single-year American Community Survey (ACS) at the state level, I tie in estimates of median household income, total state population, and the poverty rate to GoFundMe data aggregates at the state-level.

4.3 Organizer Race and Gender

I am able to extract the organizer’s name from campaign data to estimate the race and gender for the campaign organizer. Previous literature has generated mappings between race and gender for first names utilizing Census and Social Security Administration (SSA) data (Tzioumis, 2018). Additional research has used these mappings to generate conditional probabilities based on population estimates by name and race/gender. These estimates are stored in a R package for public research.³ I utilize this R package and the first name of the campaign organizer to tie in estimates of race and gender. The name of the organizer

³<https://jacobkap.github.io/predictrace/articles/Predict-race-of-surname.html>

is subsequently removed after these demographic estimates are linked. The majority of campaigns seem to be published by white individuals in addition to more than 50% coming from female campaigners.

4.4 UI Claims

The Department of Labor (DOL) tracks UI claims data through the Employment and Training Administration (ETA) reports. These data account for federal UI extensions including UI claims covered by the FPUC and PUA. I control for the number of PUA claims over time to isolate the effect that FPUC claim access has on GoFundMe campaigning.

4.5 COVID-19 Cases

I utilize state-wide covid data captured by the COVID Tracking Project from the Atlantic. Covid cases are measured by number of hospitalizations in a state, over time. Controlling for covid hospitalizations allows us to proxy for covid intensity and its effect on economic conditions.

4.6 Local Area Unemployment Statistics

The Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) tracks monthly employment statistics at different geographic levels. I augment the GoFundMe data by joining in monthly unemployment rates at the state level to capture the effect of the labor market on GoFundMe campaigning.

5 Methodology

5.1 Effects of Federal UI Benefits

Anecdotal evidence suggests that worsening economic conditions, along with access to public benefits, led to an increase in crowdfunding and new dedicated channels for crowdfunding

on GoFundMe. Given the increase in federal UI benefits, I utilize the timing of benefit payments to estimate the effect on the number of campaigns published in states. To specify, I control for the week each state began to disburse payments for each program. I model the outcome in a two-way fixed-effects specification controlling for current economic and COVID condition.

$$y_{s,t} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{POST}_{s,t} + \delta \ln(\text{COVID}_{s,t}) + \gamma X_{s,t} + \alpha_s + \alpha_t + \varepsilon_{s,t} \quad (1)$$

I estimate y which are campaign outcomes of interest including the log number of campaigns, log number of donations, and log amount donated. The coefficient of interest is β_1 , which is the estimated effect of receiving benefits in treated state s in week t . *POST* (the *treat* indicator) equals one for any week in which a state was disbursing a federal UI supplement — the FPUC-\$600 program (spring–summer 2020), Lost Wages Assistance, or the reinstated FPUC-\$300 program (2021). The pooled *treat* coefficient therefore captures a blended intent-to-treat effect of supplemental UI availability across these programs. Because the FPUC-\$600 rollout is the first and largest of the three and its start date varies across states, the event-study and Sun-Abraham checks reported below isolate that rollout as the primary source of identifying variation. I include controls for state and year-week fixed effects, log number of COVID cases, and time-varying state-level covariates like the unemployment rate and unemployment claims made. Standard errors are clustered at the state level.

One threat to identification is that personal receipt of benefits is correlated with individual propensity to crowdfund. In this case, it is reasonable to assume that the inherent state UI program workload capacity, or the efficiency with which they can disburse benefits, is uncorrelated with an individual’s propensity to crowdfund, conditional on labor market factors and state and time-fixed effects. It’s important to note that other economic stimulus

payments were uncorrelated with the timing of state benefit disbursement, as stimulus payments were administered federally and did not coincide with federal UI funding administered to states. Despite the growing trend in crowdfunding, previous research suggests that access to public insurance would lead to decreases in crowdfunding. We test this hypothesis for each of the crowdfunding categories to examine whether these effects vary across different types of campaigning.

5.2 Results

In Table 14, I estimate this model on the overall number of campaigns published in a state each week. The reported specification is population-weighted, to better reflect inherent state characteristics like size and crowdfunding popularity. I find no statistically significant effects for the outcomes of interest. The point estimate on log amount donated is a decrease of approximately 3.4% but is not statistically distinguishable from zero. Although these results suggest no general effects from changes to federal UI benefits at the aggregate level, we can separate campaigns by category to model effects for different types of charitable campaigning.

In Table 15, I examine the effect of federal UI benefits on the number of campaigns published by category. The substitution effect is concentrated in the financial-emergency category. Access to federal UI benefits decreases the number of financial-emergency campaigns in a state-week by approximately 15.6% on average, all else equal, statistically significant at the 5% level. The corresponding business-campaign estimate is a 5.9% decline that is not statistically significant; other categories (medical, memorial, family, etc.) show point estimates indistinguishable from zero. While the financial-emergency estimate is statistically significant, the economic significance is modest — the average number of financial-emergency campaigns published in a given state-week is approximately 2, on average, reflecting that the category was not created until October 2020 and that many less dense states have infrequent campaigns. If we consider financial-emergency campaigns as a substitute for UI (where they are smoothing similar consumption items: rent, food, and monthly bills), then intuition

would suggest we would see a drop in campaigns with increased access to UI benefits. Given that UI is the largest mitigator of the drop in consumption experienced over unemployment, these large federal UI changes translate to detectable effects on the most-direct-substitute category of crowdfunding (East and Kuka, 2015). The business-category channel does not recover under the bad-control sensitivity exercise (Section 6): with the post-treatment claims controls removed, the business-campaign point estimate actually shrinks slightly (from 5.9% to 4.0%, both insignificant). The fin-emergency coefficient, by contrast, grows in magnitude (from 15.6% to 20.0%) when the bad controls are dropped, consistent with those variables absorbing part of the UI-claims-mediated substitution effect. The null on business is therefore robust to the over-controlling concern. Since we cannot reconcile individual benefit receipt with crowdfunding campaigns, we do not estimate the average treatment effect of the treated (ATT), but rather intent to treat (ITT) effects of large-scale federal UI reforms.

To show the effect in aggregate, we can perform a back of the envelope calculation to show the total estimated decrease in campaigns. Multiplying our estimated effect by our average number of financial emergency campaigns published in each state-week (2.06), we get a 0.322 campaign reduction. This combined with the number of treated state-weeks where benefits were available (1,845) leads to an estimated decrease of approximately 593 campaigns over the sample period. Along the intensive margin, the average amount raised for these campaigns was approximately \$6,215. This would have led to an estimated decrease of crowdfunding of approximately \$3,685,437 on average — a modest share of overall funds raised over the sample period. Although these estimates are not huge compared to the amount spent in federal UI benefits, it provides a baseline to understand how crowdfunding may change in response to UI access. As crowdfunding continues to grow and UI becomes more restrictive across states, access to public insurance like UI will play a role in how people campaign for financial emergencies and their businesses

5.3 Does the Size of Benefits Matter?

The overall employment shock caused by the COVID-19 pandemic not only led to some of the largest increases in access to UI but also the level of UI provided as well. I exploit the level of benefits provided by federal policies during the sample period to see if it affects the amount requested in campaigns. (Gruber, 1997) finds that a change in benefit size affects subsequent consumption levels. I test whether the size of benefits affect changes in campaigning along the intensive margin. To capture the effect of UI benefit amount on amount requested in a campaign, I estimate the following model:

$$\begin{aligned} y_{c,s,t} = & \beta_0 + \beta_1 600 \text{fpuc}_{s,t} + \beta_2 lwa_{s,t} \\ & + \beta_3 300 \text{fpuc}_{s,t} + \delta \text{COVID}_{s,t} \\ & + \gamma X_{s,t} + \alpha_s + \alpha_t + \varepsilon_{c,s,t} \end{aligned} \tag{2}$$

In this model, y is the goal amount requested by campaign c in state s in week t . I control for the waves of different federal UI benefits based on the program and amount supplemented. The coefficients of interest are β_1 and β_3 which represent a dummy variable that is equal to one when benefits for that program are being disbursed. Similar to the first equation, I control for COVID intensity by including the number of registered cases, labor market measures, and state and year-week fixed-effects.

The identification assumption assumes that conditional on these observable factors and fixed-effects, the timing of benefit payments is uncorrelated with other unobservable factors that influence the size of the campaign. This is a reasonable assumption given the random disbursement timing and the uniform benefit amounts across all claimants. In Table 17, I find no statistically significant effects when controlling for the specific federal program on the goal amount of campaigns. All coefficient estimates are relatively small in magnitude, and would suggest a negative effect.

We also examine whether these effects vary by the campaigner’s race. While (Ganong et al., 2020) finds that black and hispanic households are twice as sensitive to income shocks, which would suggest higher goal amounts for ethnic households, changes to UI benefits might not have any affect on goal amounts due to lower take-up rates for minority households (Kuka, 2020). Using predicted probabilities to categorize race of campaigners, I break out the estimated effects for whites, asians, blacks, and hispanics on changes for campaign goal amounts in Table 18. Results vary across race and the different UI programs with most point estimates being statistically insignificant. However, I find a weakly significant and positive effect of approximately 6% on campaign goal amounts for Hispanics during the 300 FPUC benefit wave. This contrasts with a strong, statistically significant and negative effect for Whites on campaign goal amount during the 300 FPUC wave. Although it is unclear of the mechanism causing the difference in estimates, it does suggest heterogeneity across race for crowdfunding outcomes which aligns with previous research.

6 Additional Robustness Checks

The baseline TWFE estimates are complemented by the Sun-Abraham (2021) heterogeneity-robust event study and the Poisson PPML estimates that handle log-of-zero issues already reported above. I add several additional checks to address residual concerns about identification.

6.1 Functional Form: Log Specification vs. Poisson PPML

The category-level analysis in Table 15 estimates $\log(\text{num_X} + 1)$ as the outcome to retain state-weeks where a category had zero campaigns. As a sensitivity check, I re-estimate the main category effects using Poisson PPML with the count itself as the outcome — this is more appropriate when zeros are mechanical (e.g., a category did not exist that week) rather than truncation, and avoids the small-count bias of the $\log(1 + y)$ transformation. Table 1

reports the results.

The functional form matters substantively for the business-campaign coefficient. The log specification produces a 5.9% point estimate that is not statistically distinguishable from zero, while the Poisson specification produces a coefficient corresponding to a 11.7% decline, statistically significant at the 5% level. The financial-emergency coefficient, by contrast, is negative and statistically significant in both specifications, though the Poisson estimate is larger in magnitude (15.6% in logs, 20.4% in Poisson).

Two readings are defensible. (i) For categories with many zero state-weeks — including business, which is a small share of campaigns in most state-weeks — Poisson PPML is the better-suited functional form, and the substitution effect on business campaigns is therefore real. (ii) The disagreement across specifications suggests the business-campaign result is not robust, and the conservative read is to treat it as an unresolved null. I report both and let the reader draw their own conclusion. The financial-emergency substitution effect is unaffected by this choice.

6.2 Bad-Control Sensitivity

The main TWFE specification controls for weekly state-level UI activity (initial claims, continued claims, insured unemployment rate, PUA initial claims). These variables are themselves *outcomes* of the treatment — when federal UI benefits become available, more individuals file claims — so conditioning on them absorbs precisely the channel through which FPUC should affect crowdfunding. This is the canonical bad-control problem (Angrist and Pischke, 2009, §3.2.3).

Tables 2 and 3 re-estimate the main and by-category specifications using only pre-determined state characteristics (`median_income` and `percent_poverty`) alongside the state and year-week fixed effects, dropping the claims-side controls. The shifts are heterogeneous:

- **Financial-emergency** category coefficient *grows* in magnitude from 15.6% to 20.0% (significant at the 5% and 1% levels, respectively), consistent with the claims-side

Table 1: Poisson PPML Robustness: Campaign Counts

	campaigns Overall (1)	num_financial_emergency Fin. Emergency (2)	num_business Business (3)
treat	-0.0602* (0.0361)	-0.2037*** (0.0761)	-0.1168** (0.0592)
median_income	-2.6×10^{-5} (2.29×10^{-5})	0.0001** (4.61×10^{-5})	-6.85×10^{-5} (4.52×10^{-5})
percent_poverty	-0.0971 (0.0901)	-0.0968 (0.2080)	0.1992 (0.2539)
cases	$4.7 \times 10^{-6***}$ (8.95×10^{-7})	$3 \times 10^{-6***}$ (5.66×10^{-7})	$3.65 \times 10^{-6***}$ (5.43×10^{-7})
initial_claims	$2.06 \times 10^{-7*}$ (1.23×10^{-7})	$1.41 \times 10^{-6***}$ (3.14×10^{-7})	1.46×10^{-7} (1.71×10^{-7})
insured_unemployment_rate	0.0026 (0.0036)	0.0277 (0.0304)	-0.0043 (0.0088)
continued_claims	-1.34×10^{-8} (1.73×10^{-8})	1.89×10^{-8} (6.75×10^{-8})	3.55×10^{-8} (3.03×10^{-8})
puaIC	$3.19 \times 10^{-7**}$ (1.54×10^{-7})	9.3×10^{-8} (6.6×10^{-7})	-2.11×10^{-7} (1.58×10^{-7})
Observations	5,306	5,049	5,299
state fixed effects	✓	✓	✓
year-week fixed effects	✓	✓	✓

controls absorbing part of the UI-claims-mediated substitution effect. The cleaner specification recovers a quantity closer to the structural reduced-form effect of FPUC availability on this category.

- **Aggregate log amount donated** coefficient *shrinks* from 3.4% to 2.3% (both insignificant). The same is true for log campaigns (3.0%) and log donations. The aggregate null appears robust to the bad-control fix — there is no large substitution effect at the overall state level.
- **Business** category coefficient *shrinks* from 5.9% to 4.0% (both insignificant), indicating the business-channel null is not an artifact of over-controlling. If a substitution effect for business campaigns exists, it is below the detection threshold of this design.

This robustness check thus tightens rather than dilutes the headline narrative: the substitution channel operates through the financial-emergency category, and is detected more clearly when its mediator (UI claims activity) is not partialled out.

Table 2: Main Specifications without Post-Treatment Controls (Bad-Control Fix)

	log(campaigns) Log Campaigns (1)	log(donationsTotal) Log Donations (2)	log(amountTotal) Log Amount (3)
treat	-0.0305 (0.0237)	0.0022 (0.0336)	-0.0227 (0.0495)
median_income	$-5.19 \times 10^{-5***}$ (7.85×10^{-6})	$-6.52 \times 10^{-5***}$ (1.61×10^{-5})	$-7.03 \times 10^{-5***}$ (1.81×10^{-5})
percent_poverty	-0.0441 (0.0468)	0.0820 (0.0730)	0.0633 (0.0673)
R ²	0.97294	0.92865	0.88407
Observations	5,306	5,306	5,306
state fixed effects	✓	✓	✓
year-week fixed effects	✓	✓	✓

Table 3: Category Specifications without Post-Treatment Controls (Bad-Control Fix)

	log(num_emergency+1) Emergency (1)	log(num_medical+1) Medical (2)	log(num_memorial+1) Memorial (3)	log(num_financial_emergency+1) Fin. Emerg. (4)	log(num_family+1) Family (5)	log(num_volunteer+1) Volunteer (6)	log(num_community+1) Community (7)	log(num_business+1) Business (8)	log(num_education+1) Education (9)
treat	0.0528 (0.0488)	-0.0091 (0.0186)	-0.0410 (0.0324)	-0.1999*** (0.0694)	-0.0203 (0.0338)	0.0465 (0.0372)	-0.0268 (0.0509)	-0.0402 (0.0569)	-0.0672 (0.0442)
median_income	$-7.75 \times 10^{-5**}$ (3.08×10^{-5})	$-5.38 \times 10^{-5***}$ (1.52×10^{-5})	-4.7×10^{-6} (1.51×10^{-5})	0.0004*** (0.0001)	-7.81×10^{-6} (1.46×10^{-5})	-0.0001*** (1.54×10^{-5})	-0.0002*** (2.04×10^{-5})	-0.0002*** (2.47×10^{-5})	$-9.16 \times 10^{-5***}$ (1.39×10^{-5})
percent_poverty	0.0450 (0.1014)	-0.0141 (0.0509)	-0.1154* (0.0607)	-0.3444 (0.3256)	-0.1102* (0.0625)	-0.0506 (0.1023)	-0.0681 (0.1005)	0.1381 (0.1443)	0.0653 (0.0781)
R ²	0.88289	0.95048	0.94908	0.75882	0.80804	0.74425	0.80924	0.74770	0.81190
Observations	5,306	5,306	5,306	5,306	5,306	5,306	5,306	5,306	5,306
state fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
year-week fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

6.3 Pre-Trends Tests and Sensitivity to Parallel-Trends

A formal joint F-test of pre-period leads in the event-study specification yields a p -value of 0.010 for the total-campaign outcome — a rejection of the null of parallel trends at the 5% level. The corresponding test for the financial-emergency outcome could not be computed because the category did not exist before its October 2020 launch (pre-period coefficients are mechanically zero in this window). This pre-trend rejection in the total-campaign series motivates the partial-identification approach reported below.

To address the dependence of the headline result on parallel trends, I apply the framework of Rambachan and Roth (2023) ("Honest DiD"), which provides partial-identification bounds on the ATT that are consistent with pre-period deviations up to $\bar{M}$ times the maximum pre-period violation. Table 4 reports the bounds for the total-campaign outcome. At $\bar{M} = 1$, where post-treatment violations may be as large as the largest pre-period violation, the identified set is $[-0.2989, 0.3902]$. The set contains zero at every value of $\bar{M}$ considered. The aggregate campaign effect is therefore not robust to pre-trend violations of even moderate size, which is consistent with the small and statistically insignificant aggregate estimates in Table 14. These bounds apply to total campaigns; the financial-emergency result is identified from the category-level specification rather than from this event study.

Table 4: Honest DiD (Rambachan-Roth 2023) Bounds on the Total-Campaign ATT

Mbar	Lower	Upper
0.5	-0.1619	0.2472
1.0	-0.2989	0.3902
1.5	-0.4498	0.5412
2.0	-0.6027	0.6941

6.4 Donut Analysis

To address potential anticipation or implementation-noise around the treatment cutoff, I drop the ± 2 weeks immediately surrounding each state's first FPUC disbursement and re-estimate the main TWFE. Table 5 reports the baseline alongside this donut specification.

Table 5: Donut Robustness: Log Total Campaigns

	log(campaigns)	
	Baseline	Donut +/- 2wk
	(1)	(2)
treat	-0.0348 (0.0231)	0.0117 (0.0270)
median_income	$-2.1 \times 10^{-5*}$ (1.25×10^{-5})	
percent_poverty	-0.0999** (0.0437)	
cases	$3.79 \times 10^{-6***}$ (7.64×10^{-7})	$2.93 \times 10^{-6***}$ (4.71×10^{-7})
initial_claims	$4.76 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.16×10^{-7})	$4.44 \times 10^{-7***}$ (9.5×10^{-8})
insured_unemployment_rate	0.0005 (0.0027)	0.0024 (0.0034)
continued_claims	-3.5×10^{-9} (2.26×10^{-8})	-6.64×10^{-9} (2.74×10^{-8})
puaIC	2.16×10^{-7} (1.98×10^{-7})	$4.71 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.07×10^{-7})
R ²	0.97595	0.97842
Observations	5,306	2,399
state fixed effects	✓	✓
year-week fixed effects	✓	✓

6.5 Placebo Treatment

As a placebo test, I shift each state's treatment date 12 weeks earlier within the same calendar year. The "treatment" now spans a pre-COVID period during which no federal supplements were actually paid. Table 6 reports the placebo coefficient of 9.0% (SE 5.8%)

alongside the actual-treatment baseline; the placebo coefficient should be close to zero under valid identification.

Table 6: Placebo Treatment: Shifting FPUC 12 Weeks Earlier

	log(campaigns)	
	Actual FPUC	Placebo (-12wk)
	(1)	(2)
treat	-0.0348 (0.0231)	
median_income	$-2.1 \times 10^{-5*}$ (1.25×10^{-5})	
percent_poverty	-0.0999** (0.0437)	
cases	$3.79 \times 10^{-6***}$ (7.64×10^{-7})	$4.87 \times 10^{-6***}$ (1.28×10^{-6})
initial_claims	$4.76 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.16×10^{-7})	$5.29 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.35×10^{-7})
insured_unemployment_rate	0.0005 (0.0027)	-0.0031 (0.0032)
continued_claims	-3.5×10^{-9} (2.26×10^{-8})	-8.09×10^{-9} (1.89×10^{-8})
puaIC	2.16×10^{-7} (1.98×10^{-7})	2.63×10^{-7} (1.59×10^{-7})
treat_placebo		-0.0896 (0.0580)
R ²	0.97595	0.97445
Observations	5,306	2,650
state fixed effects	✓	✓
year-week fixed effects	✓	
week fixed effects		✓

6.6 Heterogeneity by State UI Replacement Rate

If crowdfunding substitutes for UI, the effect should be stronger in states where UI replaces more of pre-unemployment income. I interact treatment with the pre-pandemic state-specific average UI replacement ratio. Table 7 reports the heterogeneity coefficient -0.229 for both financial-emergency and business campaigns.

Table 7: Heterogeneity by State UI Replacement Rate

	log(num_financial_emergency+1) Fin. Emergency (1)	log(num_business+1) Business (2)
treat	-0.0542 (0.1464)	-0.1278 (0.1218)
treat_x_rep	-0.2286 (0.2796)	0.1550 (0.2387)
median_income	0.0002** (0.0001)	-1.99×10^{-5} (5.05×10^{-5})
cases	$5.79 \times 10^{-6***}$ (5.93×10^{-7})	$5.02 \times 10^{-6***}$ (1.07×10^{-6})
initial_claims	-4.03×10^{-7} (4.68×10^{-7})	$1.88 \times 10^{-6***}$ (2.49×10^{-7})
insured_unemployment_rate	0.0517*** (0.0174)	0.0136* (0.0075)
continued_claims	$-4.96 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.31×10^{-7})	$2.25 \times 10^{-7***}$ (2.71×10^{-8})
puaIC	4.76×10^{-7} (6.82×10^{-7})	$-7.1 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.54×10^{-7})
R ²	0.77942	0.77247
Observations	5,306	5,306
state fixed effects	✓	✓
year-week fixed effects	✓	✓

6.7 Wild Cluster Bootstrap Inference

Asymptotic cluster-robust standard errors are known to over-reject the null with few clusters. With approximately 38 effectively-treated states, I report restricted (null-imposed) wild-cluster-bootstrap p -values (Cameron, Gelbach, and Miller, 2008) for the headline coefficients. Table 8 shows the bootstrap p -values are 0.047 for financial-emergency and 0.335 for business campaigns. The bootstrap values are modestly larger than their asymptotic counterparts — indicating mild finite-sample anti-conservatism — but they leave the substantive conclusions unchanged: the financial-emergency effect remains significant at the 5% level, while the business estimate remains statistically indistinguishable from zero.

Table 8: Wild Cluster Bootstrap p -values vs. Asymptotic Cluster-Robust

Specification	Cluster p -value	Wild bootstrap p -value
Log Campaigns (diff1)	0.1387	0.1807
Fin. Emergency (diff2)	0.0131	0.0473
Business (diff2)	0.2364	0.3353
Fin. Emerg. Post-Launch (diff3)	0.0297	0.0483

Restricted (null-imposed) Rademacher wild cluster bootstrap, 2999 draws, clustered on state.

6.8 Alternative Identification: The 2021 Benefit Termination

The baseline design identifies effects from the staggered *onset* of the FPUC-\$600 supplement in spring 2020. However, the financial-emergency category did not exist until October 2020, so the outcome is mechanically near-zero during that identifying window and contributes little to identifying the headline result. As a sharper test, I exploit the staggered *early termination* of the FPUC-\$300 supplement in summer 2021, when approximately half of states ended federal benefits before the September 4th federal expiration (Holzer et al., 2021). During this window the financial-emergency category exists throughout, so the identifying variation and the outcome overlap in time. If crowdfunding substitutes for UI, removing benefits should *increase* financial-emergency campaigns — the mirror image of the baseline result.

Because states selected into early termination on observable characteristics, I estimate the Callaway and Sant’Anna (2021) group-time average treatment effect using inverse-propensity weighting on baseline state observables (median income and the poverty rate), with never-terminating states as the comparison group. Table 9 reports the results. Ending benefits increases financial-emergency campaigns by approximately two per state-month and raises overall campaigning, consistent with the substitution mechanism and obtained where the baseline design is weakest. An inverse-propensity-weighted two-way fixed-effects cross-check agrees in sign and magnitude.

Table 9: Effect of FPUC-\$300 Termination (Callaway-Sant’Anna, IPW)

Outcome	ATT	Std. err.	Sig. (5%)
Financial emergency (count)	2.0000	0.4416	Yes
All campaigns (count)	58.5745	8.7191	Yes
Total amount raised	688009.4468	120946.2935	Yes
Fin. emerg. (excl. VT, NH)	2.0000	0.5271	Yes

Callaway-Sant’Anna (2021) ATT, inverse-propensity weighted on baseline poverty and median income; never-treated controls; monthly. Treatment = early FPUC-\$300 termination.

These estimates warrant caution. Under a conservative design-based randomization test — reassigning termination timing across states — the simple difference-in-differences interaction carries a p -value of approximately 0.16, so the termination effect is suggestive rather than decisive. I therefore read it as corroborating evidence for the substitution channel rather than as independent confirmation.

6.9 Decomposing the Composite Treatment

The baseline *treat* indicator pools three distinct programs (FPUC-\$600, Lost Wages Assistance, and FPUC-\$300) that switch on and off at different times. Because this treatment is non-absorbing, a single two-way fixed-effects coefficient can mask heterogeneity and is vulnerable to contaminated comparisons. Table 10 separates the three programs into distinct indicators on the count outcomes. The decomposition shows that the cleanest 2021 period

(FPUC-\$300, when the category fully exists) drives statistically significant declines in business campaigns and in overall campaigning, while the large FPUC-\$600 financial-emergency coefficient reflects the pre-category window discussed above and should not be interpreted as a substitution effect.

Table 10: Program-Specific Effects on Campaign Counts

	log(num_financial_emergency+1) (1)	log(num_business+1) (2)	log(campaigns+1) (3)
FPUC-\$600	-0.2952*** (0.1080)	-0.1016 (0.1182)	0.1605* (0.0881)
LWA	-0.1066* (0.0625)	0.0434 (0.0604)	0.0173 (0.0261)
FPUC-\$300	-0.1772 (0.1122)	-0.1438** (0.0703)	-0.1180*** (0.0312)
R ²	0.77953	0.77286	0.97678
Observations	5,306	5,306	5,306
state fixed effects	✓	✓	✓
year-week fixed effects	✓	✓	✓

As a final check on outcome definition, I construct a description-based proxy for financial-emergency-like campaigns using job-loss keywords, available for the full 2020–2021 period (and therefore present during the FPUC-\$600 window). The treatment effect on this proxy is a small and statistically insignificant decline (Table 11). The proxy captures job loss rather than the rent-and-bills consumption-smoothing concept of the official category and flags fewer than one percent of campaigns, so it is a low-power test; nonetheless, the headline magnitude does not generalize to this alternative outcome, which I note transparently.

6.10 Heterogeneity-Robust Estimates by Treatment Episode

The *treat* indicator turns on and off over the sample period. The baseline two-way fixed-effects coefficient may therefore compare newly treated states to states whose treatment changed earlier, and these comparisons can receive negative weights when effects are heterogeneous or dynamic (de Chaisemartin and D’Haultfœuille, 2020). I re-estimate the effects

Table 11: Effect on Text-Based Financial-Emergency-Like Campaigns

	log(num_finlike+1)	
	(1)	(2)
Treat (any supplement)	-0.0343 (0.0430)	
FPUC-\$600		-0.0106 (0.1183)
LWA		-0.0072 (0.0669)
FPUC-\$300		-0.0632 (0.0550)
R ²	0.64908	0.64914
Observations	5,306	5,306
state fixed effects	✓	✓
year-week fixed effects	✓	✓

with the de Chaisemartin and D’Haultfoeuille (2026) estimator, which compares states whose treatment changes in a given week to states whose treatment has not yet changed. The estimator allows the treatment to turn off as well as on.

Only three switches in *treat* are staggered across states. The end of FPUC-\$600 (July 2020) and the start of FPUC-\$300 (January 2021) occur in the same week in nearly every state. These switches are absorbed by the week fixed effects and provide no identifying variation. I therefore estimate each staggered episode separately: the FPUC-\$600 onset (2020 weeks 1–31), the LWA onset (2020 weeks 32–52), and the early termination of FPUC-\$300 (2021 weeks 2–36). The LWA window begins after FPUC-\$600 ends, so its pre-period excludes that common drop in benefits. Each episode’s treatment is defined from that program’s disbursement dates. I use a weekly state panel with population weights and standard errors clustered by state. Following the bad-control sensitivity analysis, the main estimates omit the time-varying claims and COVID controls, and I report estimates with the baseline controls as a sensitivity check. For each episode, I report the effect in the week of the switch, the switcher-weighted average of the effects in the first four weeks, and a joint

test of four pre-switch placebos. The financial-emergency category exists only during the termination episode, so I estimate it there alone.

Table 12 reports the results. No estimate is statistically significant at the 10% level. Without controls, no joint placebo test rejects at the 10% level. With the baseline controls, the placebo test for amount raised in the termination episode rejects at the 10% level ($p = 0.06$), so that estimate should be read with caution. For total campaigns, donations, and amount raised, the estimates are small and imprecise. For financial-emergency campaigns, ending FPUC-\$300 raises campaigns by 0.106 log points on average over the first four weeks. This matches the sign of the Callaway–Sant’Anna estimate in Section 6.8. However, the estimate is imprecise, and its 95% confidence interval includes zero. The heterogeneity-robust estimates are therefore consistent in sign with the substitution mechanism but too imprecise to confirm the financial-emergency effect on their own.

7 Conclusion

As crowdfunding continues to gain popularity it will become a more conventional substitute for working income and unemployment insurance. Unemployment rose to historic levels during the pandemic and despite the large increases in federal benefits, many workers could not gain access to UI in a timely manner. We find that access to federal UI benefits have a statistically significant effect on the number of financial emergency campaigns published in states that dispurse these benefits compared to those that do not. The lack of variation in states that publish campaigns may lead to insignificant estimates but also may be due to the nascent nature of the platform. I also find that goal amounts of these campaigns are mostly unaffected by the size of the benefits offered, but do vary across different race demographics. While the underlying mechanisms are unexplained in this research, some evidence suggests that the relaxation of traditional UI requirements acted as a channel for individuals to receive public benefits that would have otherwise been satisfied through online crowdfunding. Future

Table 12: Effects by Treatment Episode (de Chaisemartin–D’Haultfœuille)

	No time-varying controls			Baseline controls	
	Effect at switch (1)	Average effect (2)	Placebo <i>p</i> -value (3)	Average effect (4)	Placebo <i>p</i> -value (5)
<i>A. FPUC-\$600 onset (2020, benefits on)</i>					
log(campaigns)	0.018 (0.076)	-0.095 (0.133)	0.25	-0.144 (0.205)	0.41
log(donations)	0.130 (0.120)	-0.194 (0.267)	0.11	-0.130 (0.268)	0.33
log(amount raised)	0.127 (0.123)	-0.215 (0.320)	0.67	-0.111 (0.299)	0.70
Switching states				49	
<i>B. LWA onset (2020, benefits on)</i>					
log(campaigns)	-0.002 (0.043)	-0.050 (0.042)	0.75	-0.021 (0.054)	0.81
log(donations)	0.060 (0.084)	-0.013 (0.092)	0.55	0.036 (0.138)	0.80
log(amount raised)	-0.116 (0.161)	-0.292 (0.242)	0.59	-0.178 (0.233)	0.57
Switching states				49	
<i>C. FPUC-\$300 early termination (2021, benefits off)</i>					
log(fin. emergency + 1)	0.047 (0.157)	0.106 (0.141)	0.44	0.086 (0.137)	0.37
log(business + 1)	-0.175 (0.138)	0.096 (0.140)	0.45	0.060 (0.123)	0.38
log(campaigns)	0.012 (0.033)	0.036 (0.028)	0.85	0.035 (0.027)	0.84
log(donations)	-0.093 (0.107)	-0.127 (0.090)	0.14	-0.116 (0.095)	0.14
log(amount raised)	-0.058 (0.125)	-0.098 (0.085)	0.11	-0.097 (0.085)	0.06
Switching states				26	

de Chaisemartin and D’Haultfœuille (2026) `did_multiplegt_dyn`, estimated separately for each staggered episode of the composite treatment. Switching states are compared with states whose treatment has not yet changed; in Panel A the last state to switch (WV) serves only as a comparison. Weekly state panel, population-weighted, standard errors clustered by state. The average effect is the switcher-weighted average of the effects in weeks $\ell = 1-4$ after the switch. Placebo *p*-value: joint test that four pre-switch placebos equal zero. Columns (1)–(3) omit time-varying controls, as in the clean specification; columns (4)–(5) add COVID cases, initial and continued claims, the insured unemployment rate, and PUA initial claims. Panel C treatment is benefit termination, so a positive sign means more campaigning after benefits end. **p* < 0.10, ***p* < 0.05, ****p* < 0.01 (normal critical values).

iterations of this work might be able to explore these notions deeper. Although there was a large increase in crowdfunding in 2020, it's still possible that GoFundMe is an under-utilized tool or might not be a perfect substitute for UI. Future work might be able to better identify treatment effects for different economic shocks. Future work can also explore theoretical ideas on social and economic connectedness that drive charitable giving and are unique to GoFundMe. This research provides new quasi-experimental work related to charitable giving and connects it to the literature on UI. My work opens various future research channels to explore the economics of charitable giving using a rich, internet data source.

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Appendices

A Figures

Help Nat Fight Stage IV Cancer



Co-organized

Morgan Benson and Nat Myers are organizing this fundraiser.

Donation protected

As many of yall know I have been laid low by a rare cancer called a sarcoma. What I thought was a prolonged lung infection turned out to be much more sinister, with growths round my hearts and pulmonary artery. On February 9th I entered the ER & have been in the hospital ever since. Doctors of varying humanity have given me days, or weeks to live, but I live by

\$175,645 raised

\$200K goal · 2.5K donations



Share

Donate now



Vanessa Gutierrez

\$25 · 2 hrs



Anonymous

\$10 · 4 hrs



Eric Rodriguez

\$36 · 2 d



james hoffman

\$50 · 5 d



Anonymous

\$20 · 5 d

See all

See top

Figure 1: GoFundMe Page Example

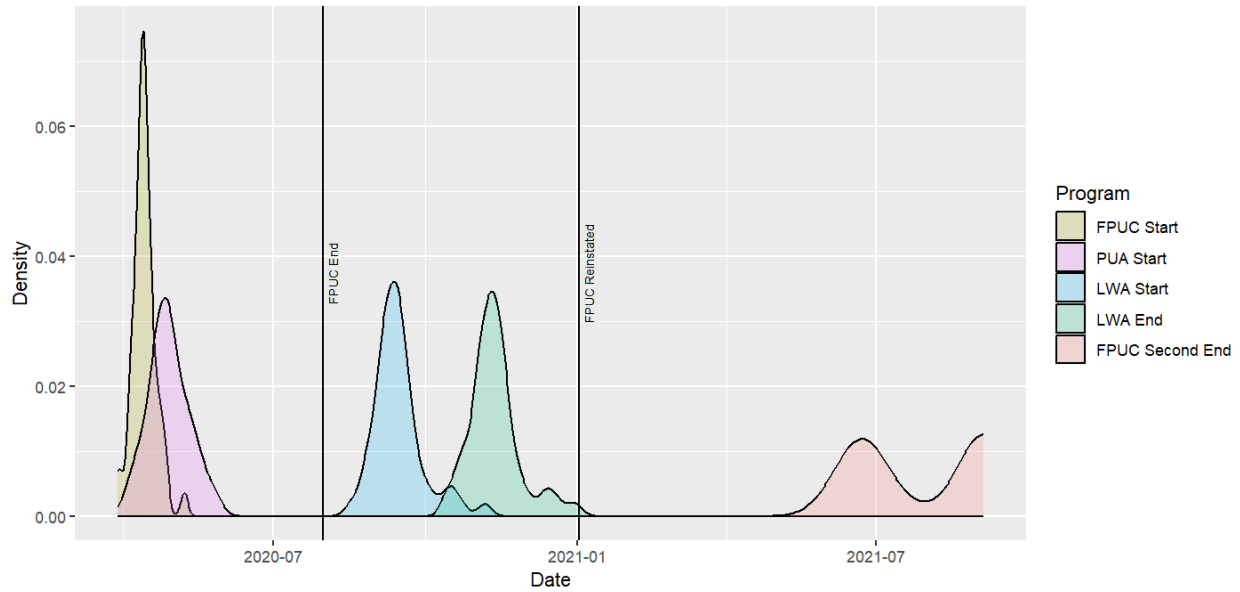


Figure 2: This figure shows the timing of first payments by program and the ending of these programs as well. Vertical lines indicate a uniform start or end date.

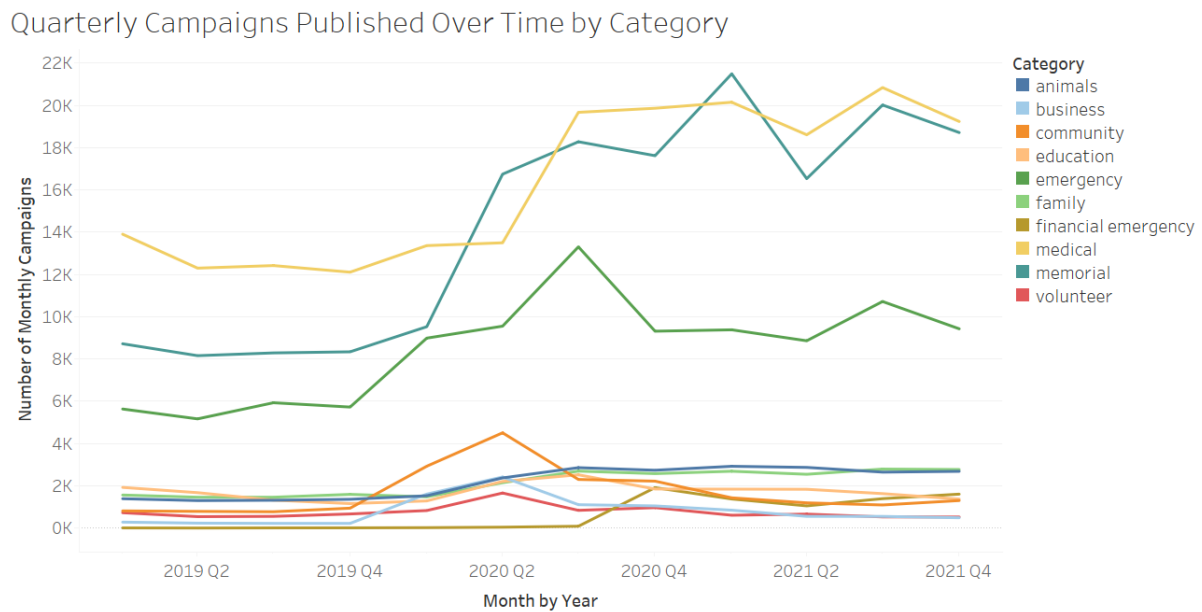


Figure 3: Quarterly Number of Campaigns Published by Category between 2019 and 2022

B Tables

Table 13: Campaign Summary Statistics

Variables	N	Mean	S.D.	Median
Goal Amount	467,888	13,580	16,757	10000
Current Amount	467,888	6469	7048	3835
Total Donations	467,888	71.3	85.2	45
Total Photos	467,888	2.61	7.77	1
Total Updates	467,888	1.93	8.06	0
Campaign Hearts	467,888	91.8	110	58
Share Total	467,888	334	720	158
Word Count	467,888	267	228	206
Met Goal	467,888	0.23	0.42	0
Single Donation	9,381,337	86.9	98.8	50
# of Campaigns	5306	90	127.5	50
Log Donations	5306	8088.8	14090.7	3753.5
Log Amount Donated	5306	9415205	509208130	342602.5

Notes: Summary statistics for all GoFundMe campaigns between 2020-2021. The top panel reflects observations at the campaign level. The bottom panel reflects observations at the state-week level. Campaigns with target and raised amounts above the 99th percentile are removed to make the sample more representative.

Table 14: Effect of Federal UI Benefits

	log(campaigns) Log Campaigns (1)	log(donationsTotal) Log Donations (2)	log(amountTotal) Log Amount (3)
treat	-0.0348 (0.0231)	-0.0045 (0.0325)	-0.0342 (0.0512)
median_income	$-2.1 \times 10^{-5*}$ (1.25×10^{-5})	$-2.49 \times 10^{-5*}$ (1.27×10^{-5})	-2.91×10^{-5} (2.76×10^{-5})
percent_poverty	-0.0999** (0.0437)	0.0103 (0.0604)	-0.0179 (0.0648)
cases	$3.79 \times 10^{-6***}$ (7.64×10^{-7})	$3.27 \times 10^{-6***}$ (9.41×10^{-7})	$4.43 \times 10^{-6**}$ (2.08×10^{-6})
initial_claims	$4.76 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.16×10^{-7})	$6.81 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.28×10^{-7})	$9.51 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.41×10^{-7})
insured_unemployment_rate	0.0005 (0.0027)	-0.0005 (0.0049)	-0.0093 (0.0063)
continued_claims	-3.5×10^{-9} (2.26×10^{-8})	-6.76×10^{-10} (1.6×10^{-8})	-1.67×10^{-8} (2.33×10^{-8})
puaIC	2.16×10^{-7} (1.98×10^{-7})	3.47×10^{-7} (2.6×10^{-7})	2.64×10^{-7} (3.9×10^{-7})
R ²	0.97595	0.93113	0.88796
Observations	5,306	5,306	5,306
state fixed effects	✓	✓	✓
year-week fixed effects	✓	✓	✓

Notes: Each observation is a state-week pair. The sample covers all states (excluding DC) between 2020 and 2021. The specification is the population-weighted two-way (state and year-week) fixed-effects model; the *treat* variable equals one for every week that supplemental federal UI benefits were paid out (or able to be claimed). Time-varying state controls (median income, poverty rate, COVID hospitalizations, and UI-claims measures) are shown. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$

Table 15: Effect of Federal UI Benefits by Campaign Category

	log(num_emergency+1) Emergency (1)	log(num_medical+1) Medical (2)	log(num_memorial+1) Memorial (3)	log(num_financial_emergency+1) Fin. Emerg. (4)	log(num_family+1) Family (5)	log(num_volunteer+1) Volunteer (6)	log(num_community+1) Community (7)	log(num_business+1) Business (8)	log(num_education+1) Education (9)
treat	0.0454 (0.0495)	-0.0198 (0.0194)	-0.0412 (0.0300)	-0.1564** (0.0608)	-0.0254 (0.0347)	0.0301 (0.0338)	-0.0406 (0.0471)	-0.0585 (0.0488)	-0.0727 (0.0448)
median_income	$-2.45 \times 10^{-5*}$ (1.36×10^{-5})	$-2.72 \times 10^{-5***}$ (1.17×10^{-5})	-3.94×10^{-7} (2.18×10^{-5})	0.0002** (0.0001)	1.69×10^{-5} (1.84×10^{-5})	$-6.44 \times 10^{-5**}$ (2.55×10^{-5})	-5.23×10^{-5} (3.65×10^{-5})	-1.97×10^{-5} (5.03×10^{-5})	$-4.58 \times 10^{-5***}$ (2.02×10^{-5})
cases	9.59×10^{-7} (1.35×10^{-6})	$1.92 \times 10^{-6*}$ (1.07×10^{-6})	$6.87 \times 10^{-6***}$ (9.73×10^{-7})	$5.78 \times 10^{-6***}$ (5.9×10^{-7})	$1.84 \times 10^{-6***}$ (4.98×10^{-7})	$3.06 \times 10^{-6***}$ (1.15×10^{-6})	$2.2 \times 10^{-6**}$ (1.03×10^{-6})	$5.02 \times 10^{-6***}$ (1.07×10^{-6})	-5.03×10^{-8} (5.42×10^{-7})
initial_claims	$7.92 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.41×10^{-7})	$5.19 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.34×10^{-7})	-3.7×10^{-8} (9.65×10^{-8})	-3.99×10^{-7} (4.66×10^{-7})	$3.83 \times 10^{-7**}$ (1.57×10^{-7})	$8.5 \times 10^{-7***}$ (2.67×10^{-7})	$1.06 \times 10^{-6***}$ (2.55×10^{-7})	$1.87 \times 10^{-6***}$ (2.49×10^{-7})	2.17×10^{-7} (2.42×10^{-7})
insured_unemployment_rate	0.0055 (0.0086)	-0.0108*** (0.0029)	0.0029 (0.0046)	0.0515*** (0.0174)	0.0032 (0.0054)	-0.0029 (0.0071)	0.0127* (0.0064)	0.0137* (0.0075)	0.0022 (0.0084)
continued_claims	-1.1×10^{-8} (2.95×10^{-8})	$5.41 \times 10^{-8***}$ (1.54×10^{-8})	-4.48×10^{-8} (3.77×10^{-8})	$-4.96 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.32×10^{-7})	-7.42×10^{-9} (2.74×10^{-8})	$1.52 \times 10^{-7***}$ (5.46×10^{-8})	$1.87 \times 10^{-7***}$ (2.37×10^{-8})	$2.25 \times 10^{-7***}$ (2.74×10^{-8})	$1.29 \times 10^{-7**}$ (6.17×10^{-8})
pualC	$1.17 \times 10^{-6**}$ (4.84×10^{-7})	$-5.04 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.65×10^{-7})	1.7×10^{-7} (2.34×10^{-7})	4.74×10^{-7} (6.81×10^{-7})	3.72×10^{-7} (2.5×10^{-7})	$-5.05 \times 10^{-7**}$ (2.22×10^{-7})	$-4.42 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.41×10^{-7})	$-7.08 \times 10^{-7***}$ (1.53×10^{-7})	-3.52×10^{-7} (2.39×10^{-7})
R ²	0.88587	0.95246	0.95546	0.77939	0.80955	0.75282	0.81741	0.77245	0.81335
Observations	5,306	5,306	5,306	5,306	5,306	5,306	5,306	5,306	5,306
state fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
year-week fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Notes: Each observation is a state-week pair. The sample covers all states (excluding DC) between 2020 and 2021. The outcome is $\log(\text{num}_X + 1)$ for each category, retaining zero-campaign state-weeks. The *treat* variable is equal to one for every week that benefits were paid out (or able to be claimed). Estimates are weighted by state population. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$

Table 16: Effect of Federal UI Benefits within Business Campaigns

	Non-Wage Campaigns Model: (1)	Wage Campaigns Model: (2)
<i>Variables</i>		
Treat	-0.1176** (0.0578)	-0.0293 (0.0731)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>		
State	Yes	Yes
Year-Week	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>		
Observations	2,227	959
R ²	0.73948	0.75102

Notes: Each observation is a state-week pair. The sample covers all states (excluding DC) between 2020 and 2021. The *treat* variable is equal to one for every week that benefits were paid out (or able to be claimed). The specification are delineated by whether the campaign descriptions mention "employees" or "wages". Estimates are weighted by state population. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$

Table 17: Effect of Federal UI Benefits Amounts on Campaign Goal Amounts

Dependent Variable:	Log Goal Amount
Category	Business
Model:	(1)
<i>Variables</i>	
FPUC600	-0.0304 (0.0295)
LWA	0.0028 (0.0053)
FPUC300	-0.0183 (0.0121)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>	
State	Yes
Year-Week	Yes
Category	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>	
Observations	1,896,445
R ²	0.10106

Notes: Each observation is a campaign. The sample covers all states (excluding DC) between 2020 and 2021. The variables of interest are equal to one for every week that benefits were paid out (or able to be claimed) for the major federal programs. The MEUC program is excluded due to coinciding directly with the 300 dollar FPUC reinstatement. Estimates are weighted by state population. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$

Table 18: Effect of Federal UI Benefits Amounts on Campaign Goal Amounts by Race

Dependent Variable: Predicted Race Model:	Asian (1)	Black (2)	Hispanic (3)	White (4)
<i>Variables</i>				
LWA	-0.0026 (0.0414)	-0.0030 (0.0339)	0.0038 (0.0151)	0.0016 (0.0065)
300 FPUC	-0.0679 (0.1052)	-0.0271 (0.0760)	0.0609* (0.0283)	-0.0698*** (0.0154)
600 FPUC	0.1458 (0.1496)	-0.0053 (0.2056)	-0.0172 (0.0934)	0.0236 (0.0378)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
State	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year-Week	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Category	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>				
Observations	47,269	46,244	241,942	1,157,602
R ²	0.1429	0.1296	0.1173	0.1077

Notes: Each observation is a campaign. The sample covers all states (excluding DC) between 2020 and 2021. The variables of interest are equal to one for every week that benefits were paid out (or able to be claimed) for the major federal programs. The MEUC program is excluded due to coinciding directly with the 300 dollar FPUC reinstatement. Estimates are weighted by state population. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$